

Open Source Tools That Simplify Tasks for C Programmers

This article will interest programmers and engineering students. It describes various open source tools that C programmers ought to add to their toolkit.



Even though C was developed around 1973, it still elicits a fair share of interest from professional programmers. But beyond this, C is also the preferred language of academia. There is possibly not a single university in the world which does not have a C programming paper in its undergraduate curriculum. The destinies of C and UNIX have been intertwined ever since they were created. C is most powerful when it is used with UNIX. In fact, the system calls and commands of UNIX/Linux invigorate C programs. Unfortunately, in India, this language is most often taught using proprietary tools. To add insult to injury, the most widely used IDE is Turbo C++ for Microsoft Windows, a product of Borland Software Corporation, an erstwhile software company. The last stable version of this IDE was released in 1996, which makes it as old as many of the first-year undergraduate students who use it. In 2006, the Turbo C++ IDE was released as freeware, which effectively tells us that the software has become obsolete. But

many people still cling to this tool, citing ease of use. I have had a difficult time convincing others how easy it is to use the Linux environment to program in C, and this article has its roots in my frustration over this argument. In this article, I have presented a few open source tools that will make the life of a C programmer comfortable in the Linux environment.

There are lots of open source tools that can be used to automate and simplify many of the steps involved in program development, using C. This list is in no way comprehensive, but the tools have been selected based on my experience and personal preferences. So the relevance of a particular tool might be debatable, occasionally, but the general idea is to introduce some useful tools to the interested user. Open source tools from the following categories will be discussed:

- Integrated Development Environments
- Build automation tools
- Revision control systems